Further reading: Bartley 2002; Buitenen 1956; Lipner 1986

**Brahma-Sutras:** a collection of very brief summaries (*sutra*), intended as aids to memory, of the main teachings of the Hindu scriptures called ***Upanishads***. The collection is ascribed to *Badarayana* and was probably composed around the beginning of the common era. With the ***Upanishads*** and ***Bhagavad Gita***, they form the triple basis of the ***Vedanta*** school of scriptural interpretation. Any thinker who wanted to be recognised as a *Vedantin* had to write a commentary explaining these pithy and ambiguous statements. The earliest surviving commentary on the *Brahma-Sutras* is that by the non-dualist (***Advaita***) *Vedantin* ***Shankara*** (700–50 CE). The theistic theologian ***Ramanuja***'s commentary is called the *Shri Bhashya*.

**Brahman:** the *Vedantic* term meaning 'Supreme Being'. ***Advaita*** understands it as an impersonal absolute beyond all oppositions, not a creator. It is just static awareness, void of differentiating features, the substratum of the false appearance of diversity. Although this *Brahman* is beyond thought and language, scriptural texts expressing identity can point us in the right direction (see ***Neti Neti***).

In ***Ramanuja***'s theistic ***Vedanta***, the Supreme Being is the personal God *Vishnu-Narayana* who is the originating and sustaining cause of the cosmos to which he is related in the way in which individual souls are related to their bodies. This maximally great and good deity comprises an infinity of delightful unsurpassable qualities. Its producing and holding in existence the cosmos is a tiny feature of the divine life. Scripture (***shruti***) describes *Brahman* as the originating and sustaining cause of the cosmos, but this is not the definition (***lakshanam***) of the term. The definition is, 'The Supreme Being is reality,